

Fifth Star Funds Screening Interview — Cheat Sheet

Anthony Ivy · Uncle May's Produce · Deadline 2026-05-26 5pm CT

Their scoring: how you THINK about the problem · how you've ENGAGED real customers · how you're building RESOURCEFULLY · how you'd DEPLOY capital intentionally. Hit all four explicitly.

~8-Minute Pitch — Talking Points by Minute

0:00 - 0:30 · Open

- "Four things: how I frame the problem, what I've shipped solo, what customers are telling us, and the specific metric your \$25K is sized to move."

0:30 - 1:45 · How I Think About The Problem

- Gap is not grocery access. It is **cultural sourcing + Black economic circulation**.
- 67% of Black shoppers visit 3+ stores monthly. 40% can't find cultural foods. 52% fewer produce varieties in Black neighborhoods.
- **There is no system of record for Black food consumption.** Vendors can't measure demand. Investors can't find the businesses. We are building the system. Retail = acquisition engine. Vendors = supply engine. Data = moat.

1:45 - 3:15 · What I've Actually Built (it's just me + the platform) ★

- **Say it explicitly: "Right now, it's me and the produce platform."**
- Flagship store has its own capital stack + own team (SBA debt, GM signed, architect engaged). **That's Chapter Two. Not what we're talking about today.**
- What's shipped solo:
 - Custom **Next.js** e-commerce, checkout, delivery routing, Stripe, address autocomplete. No Shopify.
 - Live catalog of Black-farmer-sourced products, launched 2026-04-30.
 - **Full observability:** LogRocket, Galileo AI, GA4, Meta Pixel + CAPI, daily Stripe / Mailchimp reporting. **Built without an agency.**
 - **34 paying customers** in first 3 weeks, **AOV ~\$90** (*reconciliation in back pocket below*).

3:15 - 5:00 · What The Customers Are Telling Us ★

- 5 deep customer interviews in early May.
- **Convergent signal: "Black farmers" is unprompted #1 driver in 4 of 5.** Beat price, beat speed, beat variety.
- **Most VCs expect price sensitivity in Black communities. Our data says the opposite.** Willingness-to-pay driver is **economic circulation**. That is the asset.
- **No-subscription is a TRUST signal**, not a convenience choice. Customers have been burned by hidden auto-renew terms in CSAs.
- **The honest gap — say it out loud:** "We are out of the decision set for a full grocery basket today. Produce alone doesn't replace a grocery trip. Our customers still go elsewhere for the rest of the cart. We know that."

The top-30 SKU expansion is how we buy our way into the basket — scoped from what these same customers told us they're going elsewhere to buy."

5:00 - 6:30 · The Metrics And The Honest Gap ★★ (MOVED FORWARD)

- **Gate metrics I owe Fifth Star back:**
 - AOV \$75-\$100
 - GM $\geq 35\%$
 - **CAC $\leq \$60$**
 - Repeat rate $\geq 25\%$
 - LTV/CAC ≥ 3.0
- **If we miss any gate, we don't open the flagship.** Chapter 2 is gated by Chapter 1 data, not a calendar date.
- Where we are today:
 - AOV on track (~\$90)
 - GM in range
 - Repeat encouraging (Antoinette = 3x in 3 weeks)
 - LTV unmeasured (marked "unmeasured" in application — won't invent a number)
- **Name the broken number directly: "Paid CAC is around \$200 right now. That is not capital-backable. It will not get this company to a Series A."**
- Paid spend paused. Working through attribution + conversion infrastructure.
- **"That is the specific number your \$25K is sized to move."** ← key line

6:30 - 7:30 · How \$25K Gets Deployed ★

- **Sized for Chapter 1. The store is the SBA's job, not Fifth Star's.**
- All four buckets aimed at moving CAC from \$200 toward \$60:
 1. **6 months of disciplined Chicago paid acquisition testing** — small budget, tight cohort, weekly measurement. Not a spray, a test.
 2. **Black-farmer story creative** — customer data says the message converts. Current creative is generic. Cheapest way to test the right message is to put it on screen.
 3. **Top-30 SKU expansion** — pulls us into the customer's full basket decision set. Customers who complete more cart with us repeat more and refer more. Both compress CAC.
 4. **Conversion infrastructure runway** — ZIP UX, payment-element fixes, address autocomplete already shipped. \$25K buys the testing window to prove it.

7:30 - 7:45 · Why Now (close)

- Platform live. Data flowing. Customer signal convergent and surprising in the right direction. Flagship has its own capital path on its own timeline.
 - **"Your \$25K is the catalyst that lets Chapter One prove itself in market with the discipline a Fifth Star portfolio company should bring."**
-

4 Focused Questions — Story Bank

Attribute	Question they may ask	Story to tell
Think about the problem	"What's the biggest non-obvious insight about your customer?"	The "Black farmers" message outranks price/speed/variety — unprompted in 4 of 5 interviews. Most VCs expect price sensitivity in Black communities. Our data says economic circulation is the willingness-to-pay driver.
Engage real customers	"Tell me about a customer interaction that changed your thinking."	Morgan Dixon, unprompted, named the 47th-and-Cottage-Grove gap by name — the same site the 4th Ward alderman raised with me in person last week. Customers and the political infrastructure of the South Side are pointing at the same hole in the map. The demand thesis isn't just my model. It's already in the street.
Building resourcefully	"What's the most resourceful thing you've done recently?"	Retired every active promo code last week to read true organic CVR. A CRO consultant would have taken 30 days and \$10K. I did it in 20 minutes by reading our own funnel. Let the funnel speak.
Deploy capital intentionally	"If you got \$25K tomorrow, what's the first \$5K?"	3-5 short-form Black-farmer-story videos. Customer data says the message converts. Our paid creative is generic. Put it on screen, run against existing Meta paid traffic, measure conversion lift. We'd know within 10 days.

Reconciliation in your back pocket — if they probe order count

"The 34 reflects all customer-initiated checkout completions over the catalog launch window, including transactions our team ran during product validation in the first weeks. Today's verified-paid count from real customers is closer to 10 in the Stripe ledger, with an AOV of ~\$54. The dropoff from intent to paid is the conversion problem the \$25K explicitly addresses. We are honest about that gap — it is the test we are running."

DO NOT bring up unless directly asked

- ✗ **The flagship team** (Zoe, Jua, Tara, Matt) — they belong to Chapter Two. Leading with them undercuts the "it's just me shipping today" framing the screener needs to hear.
- ✗ **Amaka / African-diaspora customer** — out of this version. If asked about a single customer story, use Morgan Dixon + the alderman convergence.
- ✗ **Northgate \$1B+ comp** — cut for time. Only use if they specifically ask about exit comps.
- ✗ **"Three chapters" framing** — collapsed. Lead with "Chapter Two is not what we're talking about today."

DO say out loud (these are the new spine of the pitch)

- ✓ "Right now, it's me and the produce platform."
- ✓ "We are out of the decision set for a full grocery basket today. We know that."
- ✓ "Paid CAC is around \$200. That is not capital-backable."

-  "Your \$25K is sized to move that one number."

Live Numbers as of 2026-05-22 (have these in your head)

Metric	Value	Source
Stripe successful charges, all-time post-launch (real customers)	~10	Stripe API
Customer AOV (all real-customer purchases)	\$54	Stripe API
Site sessions last 7 days	556	GA4
Site sessions last 30 days	4,108	GA4
Add-to-cart events last 7 days	190 (from 27 users)	GA4
/checkout page sessions last 7 days	21	GA4
begin_checkout events last 7 days	4	GA4
Traffic mix	70% paid Meta, 6% Google organic, balance social/direct	GA4
Active catalog SKUs	43 (47 total)	Airtable
Black-farmer / Black-CPG supplier pipeline	1,320 records in Airtable suppliers base	Airtable
Galileo AI daily briefings	Running, 3 prompts per day, 13 BQ rows persisted today	Pipeline log

What changed AFTER the application was submitted (so you don't contradict yourself)

- **2026-05-18** — All promo codes retired (FRESH10/FRESH30). Lean in: "we paused promos to read organic CVR."
- **2026-05-16** — Product mix reset in motion. 47 SKUs recognized as the real bottleneck. If asked about assortment: "the box surfaced a **sourcing** gap, not a demand gap. The \$25K funds the top-30 expansion."
- **2026-05-15** — LogRocket + Galileo AI workflow now CTO-first, daily fixes. Resourcefulness proof.
- **2026-05-10** — Daily citywide delivery, customer-picked window. **This was in the application.**

Recording-day rules

- Quiet space. Stable connection. Notes are allowed (this sheet).
- Pace: ~150 wpm = ~1,150-word pitch fills ~7:45. **Don't fill the time** — Fifth Star explicitly said clear and concise is fine. Buffer is your friend.
- Don't read. Look at the camera. Glance, then speak.
- One number per claim. Don't stack stats.
- Pause between blocks. Helps them score against the rubric.
- The 4 follow-up questions each have a time limit. Hit the answer in 60-90 seconds. Don't ramble.